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Serpil Oppermann

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BLUE HUMANITIES

Storied Waterscapes in the Anthropocene

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Abstract: By drawing on oceanography (marine sciences) and limnology (freshwater sciences), social sciences, and the environmental humanities, the field of the blue humanities critically examines the planet's troubled seas and distressed freshwaters from various sociocultural, literary, historical, aesthetic, ethical, and theoretical perspectives. Since all waterscapes in the Anthropocene are overexploited and endangered sites, the field calls for transdisciplinary cooperation and encourages thinking with water and thinking together beyond the conventions of tentacular anthropocentric thought. Working across many disciplines, the blue humanities, then, challenges the cultural primacy of standard sea and freshwater narratives and promotes disanthropocentric discourses about water ecologies. Engaging with the most pressing water problems, this Element contributes to those new discursive practices from a material ecocritical perspective. The author's hypothesis is that fluid-storied matter and the new stories we tell can change the game by changing our mindset.

Keywords: thinking with water, oceanography, limnology, wet matter, Anthropocene seas, Anthropocene blues, fluid-storied matter, aquatic agencies, freshwaters

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Introduction

> *The true eye of the earth is water*
> Gaston Bachelard, *Water, and Dreams*
>
> (1942/2006, 31)

> We speak of geological time as if rock were the epitome of durability. It isn't. Where rock meets water, it is water that wins in time, every time . . .
> Amy-Jane Beer, *The Flow*
>
> (2022, 59)

As a truly transdisciplinary field, the blue humanities studies planetary waters from sociocultural, literary, historical, aesthetic, ethical, and multiple other perspectives, and lays bare the broader social implications of hydrologic sciences.[1] The scholars in the field methodologically engage with the multivalent meanings of salt and freshwaters and the compounded changes all waterscapes are undergoing. The world's oceans, seas, lakes, ponds, rivers, streams, creeks, glaciers, and wetlands (i.e., marshes, swamps, fens, bogs, peatlands, estuaries, and bogs) are all in crisis today, brought about by capitalist regimes of power inhabiting the material-discursive spaces now traversed by the blue humanities. Blue humanities scholars entertain the propositions that the main problems and insecurities in aquatic ecosystems are ineluctably social and cultural; that the political systems mired within the capitalist logic are responsible for the damage inflicted on the planet's major waterways; and that the possibilities for any hopeful change are socially and culturally situated. Since our perceptions and ideas of water bodies are culturally shaped, as many scholars affirm, the best way to change the way people behave is to change the way they think. Thus, the field provides in-depth analyses of human relations with fluid sites from both material-discursive and sociocultural perspectives and offers analytical frameworks and critical pathways for studying these relations.

Accordingly, the task of this Element is to discuss human–aquatic interactions, including conceptual and metaphorical analogies of wet and dry worlds, as well as about water itself, on the one hand, and related scientific epistemologies of hydrosystems, on the other, as interactively explored in the field. I also deliberate on the discourses of narrative representations of waterscapes to signal the ideological nature of representation in narrative models. My discussion is modeled on the confluence of what came to be known as "thinking with water"[2] and the theoretical perspective of material ecocriticism.

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[1] Hydrologic sciences are the fields of study concerned with Earth's waters (see footnotes 4,10, 11).

[2] The inspiration comes from *Thinking with Water* (2013) edited by Cecilia Chen, Janine MacLeod, and Astrida Neimanis

The emergence of the term "blue humanities" is attributed to Steve Mentz who, in his 2009 article "Toward a Blue Cultural Studies," suggested that "some new developments in maritime studies" must be called "blue cultural studies" (2009a, 997). Four years later, ocean historian John R. Gillis published a feature article in *Humanities* titled "Blue Humanities" (2013), outlining the field's temporal development. In Gillis's preliminary outline, "[t]he emergence of the blue humanities is a belated recognition of the close relationship between modern western culture and the sea." However, the name of the field and the use of the term is not so new. Although not known among blue humanities scholars at the time, the term was first used in the 1940s by a famed Turkish author, Cevat Şakir Kabaağaçlı, who called himself the Fisherman of Halicarnassus and coined the term Blue Anatolian Humanism. British journalist Roger Williams explains in *The Fisherman of Halicarnassus* (2013) that the term refers to "the philosophy that developed during days and nights of discussion among the Fisherman and his Blue-ist (*Maviciler*) friends on their voyages along the Carian and Lycian shores" (2013, 92). Combining "classical literature with nature" (2013, 14), Blue Anatolian Humanism emerged from the conversations between the Fisherman and his famous intellectual friends during their Blue Voyages, which they initiated in Bodrum. Bodrum is the modern name for the ancient town of Halicarnassus, located at the junction of the Aegean and the Mediterranean seas, and where the author was exiled in 1925. Dating back to Ionians and Aeolians, the cultural heritage and the flora and fauna of Bodrum fascinated the Fisherman, inspiring him to write eleven story collections, five novels, eleven books of essays, and several memoirs, in many of which he claimed that this is where European civilization emerged. This "was the essential tenet of Blue Anatolian Humanism" (Williams 2013, 92), as evidenced in his prologue to his essay collection *A Flower Left to the Aegean Sea* (1972): "*This deep blue sky of southern Anatolia, its violet sea, light, and land, has nourished various trees, fruits, flowers, human beings, and civilizations*" (italics in the original).[3]

Other names have also been coined for the blue humanities, such as "new thalassology"[4] (Horden and Purcell 2006), "terraqueous ecocriticism" (Brayton 2012), "critical ocean studies" (DeLoughrey 2017), "humanist oceanic studies" (Price 2017), "hydro-criticism" (Winkiel 2019), and "blue ecocriticism" (Dobrin 2021). Since the oceans and their changing conditions were the prime targets of research in the field's developmental phase, they were extensively studied as sites of symbolic crossings and material connections among cultures, histories, and ecologies. That is why the field is commonly characterized by the

[3] For a more detailed account of the Fisherman of Halicarnassus, see my article "Enchanted by Akdeniz: The Fisherman of Halicarnassus's Narratives of the Mediterranean" (Opperman 2013).

[4] In ancient Greek Thalassa means "sea."

"oceanic turn" (Mentz 2009b, 2020; DeLoughrey 2017; Mentz and Rojas 2017; Winkiel 2019; Dobrin 2021), whereby scholars combine data provided by marine sciences with cultural and literary theories to modify our anthropocentrically oriented conceptions and discourses of planetary oceans. What is of utmost importance here is subverting the dominant assumptions about the seas as exploitable resources separate from the human sphere, thus emphasizing the coextensivity of human realms and the seas. Although "it cannot be our home," as Steve Mentz points out, the sea has always been part of human cultural reality "because of its metaphorical vastness," especially for "literary culture on a global scale" (Mentz 2022, 4). This coextensivity of aquatic naturecultures is not only metaphorical, however. As the Fisherman of Halicarnassus emphatically reminded his readers, it is also essential to life as we are all mostly made of water: "The bodies of land creatures are mainly composed of water. Human blood is salty like sea water" (Kabaağaçlı 1961, 246). Water in human bodies, as cultural anthropologist Veronica Strang explains, is mostly "'intra-cellular' – inside our cells. The other third is comprised of 'extra-cellular' fluids such as blood plasma, and 'transcellular' fluids, which surround the cells, carry nutrition and oxygen to them and remove metabolic wastes" (2015, 31). Mentz, too, draws attention to the interrelations of bodies, water, histories, and narratives: "multiple forms of water shape human bodies, and human histories. Different narratives become legible through our depictions of liquid salt and freshwater, gaseous vapor, and solid ice" (2022, 7).

In the blue humanities, the sea is envisioned both as a geopolitical agency and as a symbolic domain marked by the intersecting stories of the Anthropocene seas, social practices, and cultural forces. Initially, the sea narratives were mostly drawn from customary western discursive maps that usually harbor a colonialist mindset (especially the ninetenth century Anglophone maritime stories), but over the years the blue humanities has become more attentive to knowledges and narratives of non-western water cultures, thus enabling the configuration of a more capacious understanding of the role of global capitalism behind the decline of oceanic and/or hydrological systems.[5] Expanding its knowledge practices about what geographers Philip Steinberg and Kimberley Peters (2015) have termed "wet matter," blue humanities scholarship aims to raise critical awareness about the ongoing biophysical transformations in both salt and freshwaters, even if the field still maintains "a distinctly saline focus to date" (Campbell and Paye 2020, 1).

[5] Hydrology is the scientific study of the chemical and physical properties of Earth's waters and the interrelationship between water and the land surface. It is mainly concerned with the hydrologic cycle, such as groundwater, runoff, and precipitation. Hydrologic sciences are comprised of oceanography and limnology (see footnotes 10, 11).